

Designing Characters for Moonsea Rising

Although I want to give you the freedom to design a character whose story you want to tell, this is a campaign focusing on influence and intrigue in the Moonsea Empire. As a result, certain races, classes, and character concepts are not a good fit.

PCs Must Want/Need to “Play the Game”

Your character must have some investment in the Moonsea Empire and its future. You should create a character who won't back down once the chaos starts; a character who has a reason to play the Game. Feel free to use the information about noble houses and political factions to dream up fun ideas for the story you'd like to tell, or reach out to me to discuss the possibilities.

PCs Must Oppose the Charismatic General!

Your character must have some reason to oppose Maxillar Bruell, the High Stormreaver (i.e., top general in the army) of the Moonsea Empire, and his quest to become the next Stormlord. This likely means that you are not a member of the Militarist faction or of House Bruell, or that if you are one or both of those things that you are staunchly opposed to Maxillar or his plans (and, thus, opposed to the plans of your House or Faction) for some reason.

Point-Buy or 4d6, Your Choice

Players may generate characters by using a point-buy system (27 points) or by rolling 4d6 (drop the lowest die) six times in the presence of the DM.

Class/Race/Background Restrictions

Characters must use only the custom backgrounds described in the Moonsea Backgrounds document. And, sorry to say, but the Moonsea Empire is just a little bit racist and xenophobic (something the party might want to change!). So, no tieflings, tabaxi, dragonborn, or half-orcs. Your character must be able to fit in at a senatorial gala or high society event in Melvaunt, the capital city of the Moonsea Empire.

The only outright banned class is artificers, for myriad reasons. But I would also require that players check with me before choosing to play a Barbarian or Druid. In my experience, many concepts built on those classes are incompatible with an urban intrigue campaign. It is not impossible for a barbarian to become a fixture of polite society, but we will want to discuss how such a person might have come to play the Game in Melvaunt. Perhaps she was a gladiator whose victories during the Feast of the Ascension have made her popular? Same with druids, who often eschew civilization and cities like Melvaunt. I won't say you can't play a druid, but they are exceptionally rare in and around the seats of power.

Magic is Closely Scrutinized - Be Careful

While there is no hard and fast rule against creating a sorcerer or warlock, I do discourage it because almost any Moonsea citizen will be prejudiced against you if he or she knows what you are. The same is true for any divine magic from an evil deity. These are all seen as "Zhentish" or having "the whiff of the Zhentarim" (on that see more below). Thus, you will gain disadvantage on any Persuasion checks made against any Moonsea noble who knows what you are, and that is if they don't just have you killed.

It is accepted to practice divine magic from a neutral or good deity (cleric, paladin, etc.), or arcane magic learned from study as a student at an accepted arcane institution like the Laroneum. Wizards, for example, are well-respected among the nobility of the Moonsea Empire. Rangers are similarly thought to get their magic from long training/practice and from secrets passed on from those who know. The Moonsea military, known as the Stormreavers, use rangers extensively. Finally, priest, paladins, druids, and bards are thought to wield magic as a divine gift (in my version of Faerun, druids and bards are considered to have been granted their gifts by a deity - perhaps Chauntea or Sylvanus for druids, or Corellon Larethian or Millil or bards).

Priests of Mystra often get the best of both worlds, dabbling in arcane and divine magic. Priests of Loviatar, on the other hand, are killed on sight in some decent communities, but have their own temple in Melvaunt (the Moonsea Empire often uses priests of Loviatar as executioners, torturers, etc.). Learned magic is considered enlightened and the exclusive bailiwick of the nobility in Melvaunt and no one may cast a spell without a permit in the city of Mulmaster. Indeed, if you are not a noble or affiliated with a well-known institution of arcane learning (like the Laroneum in Melvaunt), members of the nobility will be hostile towards your use of arcane magic. And if you are not wearing priests robes, they may not realize you are cast a divine spell. As far as they're concerned, you have to be a member of the club to use magic.

And arcane magic of all kinds is viewed much more negatively among the poor and in the more rural areas and in the outer provinces. Sort of the way my dad, who lived in the rural portion of America's Deep South, referred derisively to the "book smarts" of his college-educated son and all those "globalist" elites using their fancy law talk to screw over the little guy!

Religion is important in Faerun, and Melvaunt is no different.

There is almost no one that does not worship one or more of the Faerunian Pantheon. Lathander and Ilmater are the most popular, but the Moonsea Empire officially has a state religion that is a recent offshoot of Lathandrism - the Church of Sun & Storm (classic state religion where the founder of the empire, Edric Storm I, is considered to have ascended to sit at the right hand of Lathander). In the highest circles of society, it is all very casual, and, although there are definitely religious zealots among the nobility, many of them are sort of relaxed and nonchalant about it, at best, and jaded, cynical, and downright hypocritical, at worst. Your character doesn't *have* to worship a god, but he or she should be ready to at least pretend in order to get by in the highest social circles.

Feats

We'll be using the optional feat rules as described in the Players Handbook, which just means Variant Humans can forego the very powerful

+1 to every ability score that humans normally get, and instead take a +1 to only two ability scores, plus an extra skill proficiency, plus a feat. This is the only way you can take the Noble Scion custom feat. If you want advice about whether a given feat might be a wise investment in this campaign or if you want to use a feat not listed in D&D Beyond, please speak to me about it.

Skills are Key

More so than most D&D campaigns, this campaign will find tons of creative and fun ways to use your character's skills and abilities. As just one example, the Medicine skill is vastly more powerful and important in this campaign than in other 5e games (for more on that, see "Healing, Medicine, and Healing Kits" below). As another example, every single skill can be used to influence an NPC, not only Persuasion (for more on that, see "Skills and Influence" below). Indeed, many nobles and politicians are actually harder to influence using Persuasion than the one or two particular skills to which they are especially susceptible.

Healing, Medicine, and Healing Kits

D&D 5e lets characters heal during a short rest without using potions or spells. In this campaign, you must expend a single use of a healer's kit to do so. This represents bandaging the wound and applying alchemical salves to the damage. Only one use of the kit is expended regardless of how many hit dice the character chooses to spend. Magical healing is much harder to come by in the Moonsea Empire than most 5e campaigns, which increases the importance of the Medicine skill, your Constitution score, healing spells, and the ability to craft your own potions or make scrolls.

Skills and Influence

Influencing NPCs is a HUGE part of an intrigue campaign like this one, but don't make the mistake of thinking that Persuasion is somehow the only skill that matters. The way I run D&D, any skill can be used to influence a character. The Nature skill might be used to influence a dog-lover or a cavalryman. The Arcana skill can be used to influence a wizard or a noble

who is interested in the subject. The History skill could help you influence a local shopkeep if it gives you knowledge about what this neighborhood used to be like "in the good old days." The Athletics skill might be just the ticket when shaking the hand of an important NPC and trying to make a strong first impression.

Every NPC has a Social Stat Block which lists her strengths, weaknesses, passions, fears, and other possible levers that can be used to influence her, as well as what might be gained from successfully doing so. As an example, consider Danver Kane, whose Social Stat Block might look like this:

Danver Kane

Background: *Danver Kane is the unsuccessful third son of an unimportant house in Melvaunt who has somehow manage to fail his way up to an important position in the Melvaunt bureaucracy.*

Appearance: *With a round face and too many extra pounds, Kane bears almost no resemblance to his fitter, more attractive siblings. Rumor has it he might be a bastard, which would explain the dark hair, weak chin, and small, beady eyes.*

Personality: *Kane is stubborn and petty, never forgetting a slight and happily using what little power he has to make life difficult for people he dislikes. But he is also a coward, and easily intimidated.*

Weaknesses: *Kane is extremely insecure about his parentage, which only makes him more insistent that others respect his noble heritage. He could find out the truth if he wasn't such a coward, but he would do almost anything to avoid knowing the truth or, if confronted with evidence of it, to keep the information secret.*

Passions: *Kane is obsessed with bear fighting and even has a rather sizable nest egg set aside from successfully betting on the fights at the Thunderdome.*

Influence: *Persuasion - DC 18; Intimidation - DC 12; History (nobility); DC 15, Nature (bears) - DC 10*

Successes: 2 checks

Benefit: *Influencing Danver Kane gives you a useful contact in the harbormaster's office, perfect for getting information about imports, exports, and the various ships, as well as their owners, and cargo. Advantage on investigation checks to find such information when you are able to make contact with Kane.*

Story Award: *If the PCs influence Danver Kane enough to move his attitude to friendly, he will warn them of any information he learns that he has reason to know would have a negative impact on the party and its plans. A*

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Although this stat block is for the DMs eyes only, understanding it might help you grok the way influence works in this campaign. Kane's weaknesses and passions can be learned by the PCs, simply by interacting with him or seeing him across the room.

A PC with an especially high Perception skill/roll might notice that Danver doesn't look like a Kane. A PC with a high History skill/roll might know that his father, William, is a well-known philanderer. Or another PC may have learned that he was seen betting at the bear pits. Or a PC with a high Insight skill/roll may sense that he is a coward just by how he reacted to confrontation in an earlier scene.

No matter how the PCs come to learn this information about Kane, understanding Danver Kane is the key to influencing him. The Influence portion of the stat block sets a difficulty check (DC) for using different skills along with the various bits of information the PCs have gleaned about his weaknesses and passions. Thus, it is clear that Kane's stubborn nature makes Persuasion just about the worst skill to use when trying to influence him. Instead, the easiest approach is to get him talking about bears with a DC 10 nature check, or to simply cower the man with a DC 12 Intimidation check.

The Successes portion tells the DM that the PCs must achieve two successful influence checks in order to receive the award specified in the

Benefit section. Note however, that the PCs must move Kane's attitude to friendly in order to gain the gain the Story Award. If he thinks the PCs are fellow bear-fight aficionados, he is more likely to become friendly than if the PCs influence him using Intimidation.

The point of the Social Stat Block is not to force everyone to focus on numbers or to ruin the fun social interactions, but rather to open the game up to a wide variety of character types. I don't want you all to feel like you have to make high charisma characters with a +9 on Persuasion in order to have fun in an influence and intrigue game. Hopefully, this example demonstrates just how much your characters can rely on all other skills and abilities, and not just the subset that most games utilize.

Speaking in Character vs. Describing What the Character Does

I love to speak in character when I play and, as a DM, I try to give each NPC his or her own unique voice. (I'm sure I fail miserably, since my NPCs probably all sound like me, but I try) I encourage you to do the same if that is something you will enjoy. And I am sure I speak for everyone when I say that we all now it can sometimes take a few sessions to "find your character's voice." Don't be afraid to experiment and have fun.

If, however, speaking in character makes you nervous or self-conscious, you should feel free to describe what your character does and says in the third person. Moreover, you should feel free to switch back and forth between the two approaches if you feel like it. No one will judge you for that (or, I hope, for any other reason...judgement-free zone!).

Even if you decide to speak in character, you should also feel free to describe what your character is feeling or thinking from time to time. I encourage this even if it wouldn't be obvious by observing her behavior if doing so might move the story forward or make for an interesting moment.